

# SPACING

DOC NO. RL-BRAND-001-SPACE-A   REV. A   RIPOSTE LABORATORIES

Riposte spacing is a loose 2px grid. "Loose" is doing work in that sentence: the scale is not a strict geometric ramp, because it was lifted from a real production site where the values earned their places. Use a step. If you find yourself wanting a value that isn't on the scale, you almost certainly want the neighbouring step instead.

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SEC.01

# 1 • THE SCALE

|           |      |           |      |           |      |
|-----------|------|-----------|------|-----------|------|
| --space-1 | 4px  | --space-4 | 16px | --space-7 | 48px |
| --space-2 | 8px  | --space-5 | 24px | --space-8 | 64px |
| --space-3 | 12px | --space-6 | 34px | --space-9 | 72px |

Read it as three bands:

| BAND                            | STEPS          | GOVERNS                                                                      |
|---------------------------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Intimate – inside a component   | 1-3 (4/8/12)   | Chip padding, gaps between a label and its value, list-item spacing          |
| Structural – between components | 4-6 (16/24/34) | Card padding, paragraph spacing, column gaps, the space under a section head |
| Architectural – between regions | 7-9 (48/64/72) | Block separation, section padding, page rhythm                               |

The rule of thumb: **never jump more than one band at a time.** A 4px gap next to a 64px gap reads as a mistake; 4 → 16 → 64 reads as hierarchy.

## STEP-BY-STEP

| STEP     | VALUE | CANONICAL USE                                                         |
|----------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| -space-1 | 4px   | Chip vertical padding (3px 9px rounds to this band), tight glyph gaps |
| -space-2 | 8px   | Inline gaps in a .pills row, <li> bottom margin, spec-header gap      |
| -space-3 | 12px  | Button vertical padding, chip horizontal padding, small card inset    |
| -space-4 | 16px  | <b>The default.</b> Card padding, <p> bottom margin, note padding     |
| -space-5 | 24px  | Button horizontal padding, gap between two related blocks             |
| -space-6 | 34px  | Grid column gap; the space below a .sechead; between stacked cards    |
| -space-7 | 48px  | Between major blocks <b>within</b> one section                        |
| -space-8 | 64px  | Section padding (padding-block) on subpages                           |
| -space-9 | 72px  | Section padding on the homepage, where sections need more air         |

## SEC.02

## 2 • CONTAINERS

Every container is **viewport-capped**. This is not optional: an uncapped 1060px container touches the edge of a phone screen, and bone paper with no margin stops reading as paper.

| TOKEN             | VALUE             | USE                                         |
|-------------------|-------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| -container        | min(1060px, 92vw) | Standard section. The default.              |
| --container-wide  | min(1160px, 94vw) | TOC-plus-content and other two-rail layouts |
| --container-prose | min(900px, 92vw)  | Blog posts, single-column documents         |
| -measure          | 66ch              | Body copy max width                         |
| -gutter           | 4vw               | Minimum breathing room at any viewport      |

CSS

```
.wrap { width: min(var(--container), calc(100vw - 2 * var(--gutter))); margin-inline: auto; }
```

**Measure beats container.** A 1060px container does not mean 1060px of text. Body copy caps at 66ch (≈ 62rem at our size); lead paragraphs pull tighter to 56–62ch because bold text at a larger size needs a shorter line to stay readable. If a paragraph is running the full width of a wide container, the container is wrong, not the measure.

## SEC.03

## 3 • VERTICAL RHYTHM

There is no baseline grid. There is a **stack order**, and it is consistent:

```
section
├ padding-block: 64px (--space-8)      ← the region's air
└ .sechead                             ← SEC chip + title + slash tag
```

```
| | └ padding-bottom: 14px, border-bottom: 2px
| └ margin-bottom: 34px (--space-6)          ← the gap a sechead always earns
| └ content
|   └ p margin-bottom: 16px (--space-4)
|     └ .grid gap: 34px (--space-6)
└ next block: margin-top 48px (--space-7)
```

Three rules govern it:

1. **A section head always owns 34px beneath it.** Not 32, not 40. This single value is what makes different pages feel like the same document.
2. **Paragraph spacing is 16px and margins collapse downward only.** Headings carry `margin: 0 0 16px` – never top margin. Space belongs to the element **above** the gap.
3. **The last child of a container never adds trailing margin.** The container's padding is the bottom edge. `.spec li:last-child { border-bottom: none }` is the same instinct.

## SEC.04

## 4 • THE BORDER-EATS-PADDING RULE

This is the one that trips people up, and it is specific to a system drawn in 2px rules.

Every structural border is **2px**, and every accent bar is **6px** (top) or **8px** (left). Those widths sit **outside** the padding box. So a card with `border: 2px` and `padding: 16px` has 18px of visual inset – and a card with `border-top: 6px solid pink` has 16px of inset on three sides and 22px on top.

**Do not compensate.** The slight top-heaviness is correct: the accent bar is a masthead, and mastheads sit proud. What you must **not** do is mix bordered and unbordered cards in the same row – the 2px difference reads as misalignment across a grid.

| COMPONENT                 | BORDER         | PADDING   | EFFECTIVE INSET |
|---------------------------|----------------|-----------|-----------------|
| <code>.spec header</code> | 2px bottom     | 8px 12px  | 8/12            |
| <code>.spec body</code>   | 2px all        | 16px 14px | 18/16           |
| <code>.note</code>        | 2px + 8px left | 14px 16px | 16/18, 22 left  |
| <code>.partner</code>     | 2px + 6px top  | 16px      | 18/18, 22 top   |
| <code>.stat</code>        | 2px all        | 20px 18px | 22/20           |

## SEC.05

## 5 • GRID & GUTTERS

Columns are equal-width and the gap is **always** `--space-6` (**34px**), at every break-point where columns exist. Below 760px, grids collapse to one column and the 34px becomes vertical spacing – the value does not change, only its axis.

CSS

```
.grid { display: grid; gap: var(--space-6); }
```

```

@media (min-width: 760px) {
  .grid-2 { grid-template-columns: repeat(2, 1fr); }
  .grid-3 { grid-template-columns: repeat(3, 1fr); }
  .grid-4 { grid-template-columns: repeat(4, 1fr); }
}

```

The **.flow exception**. Process steps are joined by → arrows that live in the gap, so **.flow .step** uses **margin-right: 26px** rather than **grid gap** – the arrow needs a box to be absolutely positioned into. At ≤640px the arrow rotates to ↓, the margin goes to 0 and a 22px flex gap takes over. This is the only place in the system where a spacing value is off-scale, and it is off-scale because a glyph has to fit inside it.

## SEC.06

## 6 • BREAKPOINTS

Three, and only three. The system is fluid between them via **clamp()**, so there is very little to change at each stop.

| BREAKPOINT | WHAT HAPPENS                                                                |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 560px      | footer.colophon goes from two columns to one; the tri-band cell left-aligns |
| 640px      | .flow stacks; arrows rotate → to ↓                                          |
| 760px      | .grid-2/3/4 gain their columns; below this everything is single-column      |

Type does not need breakpoints – every heading step is a **clamp()**, so it scales continuously. If you find yourself adding a font-size media query, use a **clamp()** instead.

SEC.07

## 7 • SPACING ON AN INK FIELD

Dark fields need slightly **more** air than bone ones, because the 2px bone rules on ink are visually heavier than 2px ink rules on bone. The system does not encode this as different tokens – instead:

- ▶ Prefer `-space-5` where you’d use `-space-4` for **padding inside** a panel on ink.
- ▶ Section padding stays the same. The change is local to components, not regions.
- ▶ `-ink-line` (`#5c554c`) dashed dividers are lower contrast than their bone-field counterparts by design; give rows one extra step of vertical padding so the dash still separates.

SEC.08

## 8 • PRINT SPACING

See `08-print.md``RL-BRAND-001-PRINT` for the full print setup. The spacing translation:

| SCREEN                     | PRINT                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>-space-4</code> 16px | 4mm                                                                                                                     |
| <code>-space-6</code> 34px | 8mm                                                                                                                     |
| <code>-space-8</code> 64px | 15mm                                                                                                                    |
| Page margin                | 15mm minimum, 18mm preferred                                                                                            |
| Rules                      | 0.5pt for 1px dashed, <b>1.5pt for 2px solid</b> – do not go below 1pt on the structural rule or it disappears at press |

## SEC.09

## QUICK REFERENCE

## CSS

```
/* the nine steps */
--space-1: 4px;  --space-4: 16px;  --space-7: 48px;
--space-2: 8px;  --space-5: 24px;  --space-8: 64px;
--space-3: 12px; --space-6: 34px;  --space-9: 72px;

/* containers */
--container: 1060px; --container-wide: 1160px; --container-prose: 900px;
--measure: 66ch;      --gutter: 4vw;

/* the three numbers to memorise */
16px  default padding and paragraph spacing
34px  under every section head, and every grid gap
64px  section padding
```

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